

Review of Space or Schema?

Rhythm, Meter, and Pitch in C. P. E. Bach's Symphony in D Major, Wq. 183/1

Article Summary

This article analyzes the rhythm, meter, harmony, Galant schematas, and form in C. P. E. Bach's Symphony in D major, Wq. 183/1 (of 1775 or 1776). The author argues that Bach manipulates both meter finding and key finding to create harmonic what Bach refers to "rational deceptions" in his instructions for improvising a keyboard fantasy. The author offers an ad hoc, multi-parametric analysis of this idiosyncratic piece, explaining its metric, tonal, schematic, and formal manipulations, and reflecting on how the work moves from ambiguity to clarity in each domain.

Overall Evaluation: Accept with revisions

Comments

This is a fantastic article that only needs a few minor revisions to be published. What follows is a list of those minor revisions.

Page 9, line 8: The author should avoid using the term "stepwise" to refer to adjacent motions within a space of only three or four notes, since our readers will have such a strong association between "stepwise motions" and spaces that have six or more notes.

Page 12, line 1 (and thereafter): I find Meyer's use of "statistical" in this context counter-intuitive, and would encourage the author to use it only when citing Meyer, and then suggest a less problematic term ("phenomenological" would be my choice).

Page 15, line 3: replace "bright" with "clear" (I think "bright" is too vague).

Page 16, line 1 (and thereafter): replace "C" with "common time" or "4/4" to avoid confusion with the note name (a reader is likely to first assume a misprint before guessing that the author meant "common time" in this context because the note name is seen in print so much more).

Page 18, line 8: change "Anrew" to "Andrew"

Page 21, line 3, "e-minor⁶": For clarity, I would avoid mixing chord names with figured bass symbols like this: either call it a first-inversion e-minor sonority or call it ii6.

Page 26, lines 3-5: Here I would disagree that it sounds premature, and it does precede a "stronger cadence" (to use Gjerdingen's words): the half cadence marked by a medial caesura that ends the first half of the exposition. All that separates it from the arrival on the cadential dominant itself is three bars, which at this tempo doesn't take long.

Page 28, Example 13: I like this Example 13 a lot, but it could be clearer. First, I would remove the arrow connecting the quarter notes to eighth notes, since that motion doesn't describe any of the music discussed so far. Next, I would replace "4-note" with "Quarter Note" as 4-note

looks like a note grouping rather than a duration value. I would then remove the hyphens in “8th-note” and “16th-note,” as that makes them look like adjectives, not nouns. Finally, I would add three Arabic numerals enclosed in circles to represent the order of fastest pulses in the movement so far (the first over “8th Note,” the second over “16th Note,” and the third under “Quarter Note.”